

Gully to Global: India's grassroots push in Esports

A sustained presence of platforms is making esports move from a largely unorganised leisure sector to a professional **pathway** adjacent to conventional sports.

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Charlie Cowdrey barely remembers the exact date of the Grand Finals of India Rising: Road to Esports World Cup (EWC). But what he remembers is that it had not rained in Mumbai for quite some time.

"I think it was the first time in however many decades that it hadn't rained through the whole of June. And then the heavens opened during India Rising. We didn't know whether anyone would make it to the venue," Cowdrey tells *Sportstar*.

"But people came, and in thousands, and stayed for hours."

It is this audience that JioBlast — whose CEO Cowdrey is — aims to expand.

"Blast — one of the leading eSports tournament organisers in the world — combines with Jio's power in the local market to reach as many users as possible. In cricket parlance, what you get is the gully cricket answer to eSports. We want to have a pyramid, but a very wide-based one," Cowdrey says.

Esports has now earned a seat at India's sporting table, with 15 athletes competing in four titles at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games 2026. But the ecosystem has several facets

to it, beyond the glitz of top-tier tournaments.

The grassroots of esports really starts in gaming parlours and on mobile phones. And Sumedha Mahajan, the India Business Head at Ampverse DMI, feels colleges are the right environment to help players transition from rookies to professionals.

Ampverse DMI runs its flagship IP as College Rivals, a collegiate esports talent hunt and youth entertainment platform. The tournament has completed three seasons and is now in its fourth iteration, which has a prize pool of Rs. 30 lakh and includes titles like Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI), EA Sports FC 26, EA Sports FC Mobile, and Blitz Chess.

"It's been built with a lot of love and passion, and the intent was that one day, eventually, college students and all stakeholders alike would be able to see this as a platform to get into professional esports," Sumedha says.

"Season one, we were in five cities: the metros — Pune, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Bangalore, and Delhi. Season two, we moved to more cities- approximately 15 cities. Then season three is when we really started moving into tier two cities. If you look at our plan for this year, we're going to 100 colleges across about 40 cities, places like Mangalore, Guwahati and Sonapat. And I think our push into tier two and

three will only keep expanding over and over."

College Rivals and India Rising are independent competitions but are part of a larger ecosystem of grassroots development, one that also saw the Indian subsidiary of Krafton — owner/publisher of PUBG — launch the Rising Star program. The Rising Star program, running into consecutive seasons, has nurtured promising athletes like Thongzalaikam 'Zalaikam' Haokip and Samir KRATOS Choubey.

Grassroots programs like College Rivals are providing a platform, while India Rising carves a pathway to the Esports World Cup. And a sustained presence of such platforms is making esports move from a largely unorganised leisure sector to a professional pathway adjacent to conventional sports.

"Look at College Rivals grand finale for the last three years — about 5,000 people visiting, paid tickets, the whole ecosystem coming together. There's something for everybody — players, their parents, their partners, people who want to cheer and casters," Sumedha adds.

Much like cricket, the road to the biggest stage may begin in gullies for esports. But with the increased presence of platforms for grassroots development, India's next esports star may currently be in a college canteen instead of an established studio.